



AFTER

Blockade duty briefly made the United States an important naval power. But despite its modern ships, it remained inferior to Britain's Royal Navy.

BRITAIN'S SUPERIOR FLEET

The Union navy's **vast expansion increased its fighting power**, but the sheer number of its ships still did not make it a match for the British Royal Navy, accustomed to patrolling the seas of the entire globe. Most Union navy ships were designed for the relatively simple purpose of enforcing the blockade near the Southern coast. They were **only lightly armed**, since their targets, the Confederate blockade-runners, carried few if any weapons.

POSTWAR DEMOBILIZATION

Before the Civil War, the United States had looked toward its vast land frontier, as opposed to trading overseas. This put limits on how much it was willing to invest in naval power. The need to blockade the Confederacy provided a temporary **surge in the navy's resources**, but after the Civil War the **Union navy was swiftly demobilized**. The United States would not become a major naval power or fight a naval war until the **Spanish-American War** in the last decade of the 19th century.